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# Supplementary Materials

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## **Members:**

Luke Sun, Kiara Wei, Winston Huang

# Social Science Fair Interview 01

## Transcript: Value and Pressure of Football Defenders

Research Team Members: Luke Sun, Kiara Wei, Winston Huang

May 28, 2026

### Transcript Metadata

|                                     |                                                            |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Project Theme:</b>               | Discussion on the Value and Pressure of Football Defenders |
| <b>Date of Interview:</b>           | Thursday, May 28, 2026                                     |
| <b>Time of Interview:</b>           | 19:52 – 20:04 (GMT+08)                                     |
| <b>Interviewer Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 100 Luke Sun                                       |
| <b>Interviewee Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 200 (██████████)                                   |
| <b>Interviewee Subject Profile:</b> | School Team Athlete (Right-Back)                           |

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### Official Verbatim Transcript

- 1 **Speaker 100 [00:01]:** Alright, you are ██████████, correct?
- 2 **Speaker 200 [00:04]:** Yes, I am.
- 3 **Speaker 100 [00:06]:** Okay. What position do you currently play on the school team?
- 4 **Speaker 200 [00:10]:** I mainly play right-back. That position, yes.
- 5 **Speaker 100 [00:14]:** And how do you define your core responsibility on the pitch? What do  
6 you primarily do, roughly?
- 7 **Speaker 200 [00:21]:** Simply put, it's getting the ball, kicking it away, and passing it to the  
8 players upfront so they can attack. To put it more complexly, when an opportunity arises, I  
9 intercept the ball and organize the transition from the backfield to the frontfield. Additionally,  
10 when the opponent attacks, we form a second line of defense to disrupt their offense.
- 11 **Speaker 100 [00:45]:** In the last match, how much of a decisive role do you think you played  
12 in the team's victory or defeat?
- 13 **Speaker 200 [00:52]:** I feel my role in the outcome wasn't huge, but I still feel there was  
14 some. Well, that's a bit of nonsense first, but I think the main reason is that I played for a  
15 relatively short time; I played for a bit and then got substituted off. However, I think I was  
16 useful because when I was playing, I helped absorb a lot of pressure for the center-backs, which  
17 maintained our defensive advantage.
- 18 **Speaker 100 [01:28]:** Understood. When your mistake leads to the team conceding a goal,  
19 do you feel intense pressure from your teammates, the coach, or the spectators? As a defender,  
20 because you missed a ball and caused a concession, you must have experienced that, right?
- 21 **Speaker 200 [01:45]:** Yes.

22 **Speaker 100 [01:46]:** Do you feel the pressure from them is heavy?

23 **Speaker 200 [01:51]:** I feel the pressure from them is quite heavy. Although I am inherently  
 24 a pressure-free person—when others put pressure on me, I don’t really convert it into internal  
 25 friction or things like that—I feel their pressure helps me realize where I need to improve, rather  
 26 than making me anxious about which direction I haven’t done better in.

27 **Speaker 100 [02:20]:** Okay. When the team wins, to what extent do you feel the credit is  
 28 attributed to your performance on the defensive line? And to what extent is it seen as the  
 29 performance of the attacking line, or the result of a collective team effort?

30 **Speaker 200 [02:33]:** I feel it’s more like the result of a collective team effort. Because in a  
 31 football match, both defense and offense are very important, right? Although some Champions  
 32 League teams might not agree, I still believe that winning is the collective outcome of the entire  
 33 team acting as a unified entity, including the substitutes on the bench. Their encouragement  
 34 gives the players on the field more fighting spirit, which also plays a certain role. So, no matter  
 35 who it is, everyone is indispensable.

36 **Speaker 100 [03:10]:** Um, okay. Do you feel that defensive players face harsher criticism and  
 37 negative attention than attacking players?

38 **Speaker 200 [03:21]:** I feel this is a very common issue. For example, if you, as the defense,  
 39 lose the ball, the opponent has a very high probability of scoring. But if you, as the offense, lose  
 40 the ball, it merely gives the opponent an attacking opportunity. It doesn’t directly lead to a  
 41 highly irreversible consequence for the team. To give a more extreme example, when the game  
 42 is intense and tied, going into extra time, if the backfield loses a ball at this moment, leading  
 43 to an opponent’s goal, it is very difficult for our side to score again in such a short time. But if  
 44 the offense loses the ball, the defense can still win it back.

45 **Speaker 100 [04:13]:** In post-match summaries or daily discussions, do you talk more often  
 46 about statistics like goals and assists, or data like passing under pressure or critical tackles from  
 47 defenders?

48 **Speaker 200 [04:26]:** I feel if a critical tackle looks exceptionally cool, people will definitely  
 49 talk about it, but generally speaking, it’s still about things like goals.

50 **Speaker 100 [04:35]:** Um, do you feel your defensive contribution is somewhat undervalued  
 51 because it’s hard to quantify like the number of goals?

52 **Speaker 200 [04:45]:** Not really, because I feel if I defend and our team wins, I feel my defense  
 53 at least helped my team. If I keep defending and the opponent pours in 5 goals, then I feel I’m  
 54 just purely bad, and there’s nothing more to say.

55 **Speaker 100 [05:03]:** In the market, they usually count goals and assists. You rarely see  
 56 people counting clearances—there are some, but the attention isn’t that high—and things like  
 57 tackle counts are even rarer. Do you think this current situation leads to the undervaluation of  
 58 players’ worth? That is, will players who lean towards being defensive-minded be undervalued?

59 **Speaker 200 [05:26]:** I feel they will be. For instance—actually, I don’t have that many  
 60 examples because I watch less football now—but I remember, for example, Piqué from Barcelona  
 61 in 16/17, he was a center-back. But he defended exceptionally well as a center-back. Although  
 62 it was largely attributed to his tall stature and excellent technique, I personally feel their success  
 63 in that season drew heavily from the success of the backline. However, over those years, the  
 64 main credit went to Messi. It’s not that Messi wasn’t good; Messi indeed could single-handedly  
 65 carry the attacking side and score many goals, which is truly strong. But you have to know  
 66 that in football, the pressure exerted on the defense is usually greater than the pressure applied  
 67 to the offense. Because when we play, the offense losing two or three chances to get one or two  
 68 goals is very worthwhile. But for the defense, if the opponent gets two or three chances and

69 scores a goal, it feels terrible.

70 **Speaker 100 [06:38]:** Oh, right. Then do you think this potential undervaluation, whether  
71 amateur or professional, affects a player's status or confidence in the team? For example, you  
72 potentially face this kind of undervaluation, right? Do you feel that way?

73 **Speaker 200 [06:58]:** Actually, I feel my situation is quite special, but I do feel a little bit,  
74 because I transitioned from midfield.

75 **Speaker 100 [07:04]:** Then do you think this potential undervaluation has affected your status  
76 or confidence in the team?

77 **Speaker 200 [07:13]:** It hasn't really affected my confidence. As for status, to put it bluntly,  
78 I didn't have much status to begin with. But personally, I think the change in status wasn't  
79 very big. Of course, I feel it decreased slightly because, in terms of impact on the game, I  
80 personally believe transitioning from midfield to right-back reduced my ability to influence the  
81 pitch. Although this change might be better for the team, so it doesn't matter.

82 **Speaker 100 [07:48]:** Um, okay, okay. As mentioned earlier, a backfield player losing the  
83 ball often leads to a direct goal, while a frontfield player losing the ball can be won back,  
84 representing a relatively lower risk. We call this the asymmetry of risk. Do you think there is  
85 any possibility to change this reality through specific measures, plans, or policies? For example,  
86 promoting the art of defending by defenders more on the internet, or teaching it more in offline  
87 football classrooms, encouraging less individual heroism and more teamwork, emphasizing that  
88 one cannot just attack but must also balance defense. Do you think there are feasible measures  
89 or plans like this?

90 **Speaker 200 [08:42]:** I feel if we want to balance the external pressure received by both sides,  
91 it might be possible. For example, if one day, as you mentioned, we promote from the opposite  
92 direction that the consequences of a forward losing the ball are more severe, and conduct  
93 campaigns through public opinion, then the pressure itself will become more balanced. But if  
94 you are talking about reducing the pressure on defenders, I feel the change won't be significant.  
95 Because a defender losing the ball and causing a defeat is a hard event. You basically cannot  
96 change this fact through external promotion.

97 **Speaker 200 [09:27]:** Right? Because it is inherently the fact that a goal was scored. Struc-  
98 turally speaking, defending is easier than attacking. So when you are attacking, losing the ball  
99 a bit more is considered normal by people. If you try to level it out by adjusting external  
100 expectations, to be honest, the gap between the blame carried for conceding a goal and the  
101 blame carried for losing the ball in the frontfield will still remain.

102 **Speaker 100 [10:03]:** Then are there any specific measures to level out this expectation? Have  
103 you thought of any?

104 **Speaker 200 [10:12]:** The first one that comes to mind right now is using the previous method  
105 of online public opinion. Another way, I feel, is to improve the overall level of the defensive line  
106 itself. For example, a three-man backline and a four-man backline are different. From another  
107 perspective, if a three-man backline concedes a goal, the blame is shared equally among these  
108 three people—excluding individual situations of who missed the ball, of course. If it's a four-  
109 man backline and a goal is conceded, this situation will be attributed to either the opponent  
110 being too strong, in which case it doesn't matter if there are three or four people, or all four of  
111 us sharing the blame simultaneously. In this case, the pressure will be distributed more evenly  
112 and won't be as high.

113 **Speaker 100 [11:09]:** So what are the specific measures?

114 **Speaker 200 [11:11]:** First, have defenders train more. Second, add more defenders.

115 **Speaker 100 [11:18]:** Add more defenders.

116 **Speaker 200 [11:20]:** That means strengthening the defensive capability of the team itself.  
117 By changing the hard strength, we reduce the probability of being overwhelmed by pressure.

118 **Speaker 100 [11:33]:** Okay, okay, okay, thank you. That's all.

*Translated from Chinese.*

# Social Science Fair Interview 02

## Transcript: Value and Pressure of Football Defenders (Winger Perspective)

Research Team Members: Luke Sun, Kiara Wei, Winston Huang

May 28, 2026

### Transcript Metadata

|                                     |                                                            |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Project Theme:</b>               | Discussion on the Value and Pressure of Football Defenders |
| <b>Date of Interview:</b>           | Thursday, May 28, 2026                                     |
| <b>Time of Interview:</b>           | 20:09 – 20:16 (GMT+08)                                     |
| <b>Interviewer Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 2 Luke Sun                                         |
| <b>Interviewee Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 1 (██████████)                                     |
| <b>Interviewee Subject Profile:</b> | School Team Athlete (Left-Winger)                          |

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### Official Verbatim Transcript

- 1 **Speaker 1 [00:00]:** You are about to cross it.
- 2 **Speaker 2 [00:01]:** You are ██████████, correct?
- 3 **Speaker 1 [00:02]:** Yes, I am.
- 4 **Speaker 2 [00:03]:** Okay. What position do you currently play on the school football team?
- 5 **Speaker 1 [00:10]:** Left-winger.
- 6 **Speaker 2 [00:13]:** Great. How do you define your core responsibility on the pitch? What do  
7 you primarily do?
- 8 **Speaker 1 [00:20]:** I am responsible for wing penetration, ball circulation, as well as assisting  
9 my teammates or scoring myself.
- 10 **Speaker 2 [00:30]:** Mhm, okay. In the last match, how much of a decisive role do you think  
11 you played in the team's victory or defeat?
- 12 **Speaker 1 [00:37]:** When was the last match?
- 13 **Speaker 2 [00:40]:** The league match, the previous one.
- 14 **Speaker 1 [00:46]:** Unfortunately, not much; I only managed to get one assist, which is a pity.  
15 However, it was a highly critical assist, so I believe it still played a key role.
- 16 **Speaker 2 [01:03]:** Key in which aspect? Defensive or offensive?
- 17 **Speaker 1 [01:06]:** Creating a threat during the offense.
- 18 **Speaker 2 [01:09]:** Pressing?

19 **Speaker 1 [01:10]:** Yes.

20 **Speaker 2 [01:11]:** Okay, during the match, if in the early stages—say, the first few minutes—  
 21 you miss a golden opportunity, but later in the match, you score a goal. Do you think people  
 22 will still hold your previous mistake against you?

23 **Speaker 1 [01:27]:** No, they won't.

24 **Speaker 2 [01:30]:** When you see backfield players—such as defenders, or people like [REDACTED]—  
 25 make a mistake, like misplacing a pass or missing a tackle, leading directly to conceding a goal,  
 26 what kind of emotional reaction do you typically have?

27 **Speaker 1 [01:47]:** It doesn't matter; as long as we didn't concede too many goals, it's fine.

28 **Speaker 2 [01:54]:** Even if it's a direct error, like a severe miss or letting the ball slip through,  
 29 it still doesn't matter?

30 **Speaker 1 [02:02]:** My mindset might be somewhat affected.

31 **Speaker 2 [02:06]:** What specific kind of impact would that be?

32 **Speaker 1 [02:09]:** Possibly, if it leads to being equalized or overturned, I might feel some  
 33 psychological pressure in the subsequent offense, which could prevent me from executing passing  
 34 and control more effectively.

35 **Speaker 2 [02:26]:** Understood. Do you agree with the statement that the cost of making a  
 36 mistake for a defensive player is far higher than that for an attacking player?

37 **Speaker 1 [02:35]:** Yes, I believe so.

38 **Speaker 2 [02:36]:** Could you elaborate on the reasons for that?

39 **Speaker 1 [02:38]:** For instance, when an attacking player loses the ball, they don't bear a  
 40 significant amount of pressure because they are not the first line—there are still people behind  
 41 to back them up. However, if a defender loses the ball, they are the final line of defense; if they  
 42 lose it, the opponent's probability of scoring directly becomes much higher.

43 **Speaker 2 [02:59]:** Mhm. Do you feel that goals and assists grant you greater exposure on  
 44 campus?

45 **Speaker 1 [03:05]:** Yes, they do.

46 **Speaker 2 [03:07]:** Compared to metrics like a defender's critical clearances, do goals and  
 47 assists carry greater topicality or generate more discussion than clearances or tackles?

48 **Speaker 1 [03:24]:** I think so. Most highlight reels focus on brilliant offensive moments; there  
 49 are rarely scenes showcasing outstanding defensive plays.

50 **Speaker 2 [03:38]:** Do you believe this extra attention is purely based on the aesthetic appeal  
 51 or skill of the goal itself, or because scoring inherently possesses greater topicality than tackles  
 52 and clearances?

53 **Speaker 1 [03:52]:** I think it leans a bit more toward aesthetic appeal.

54 **Speaker 2 [03:55]:** Meaning the aesthetic value of a goal is slightly higher than that of a  
 55 sliding tackle or defense? Right, right. Then do you think this somewhat unbalanced return  
 56 could have adverse effects on backfield players? Such as inducing a psychological state where  
 57 backfield players feel neglected?

58 **Speaker 1 [04:25]:** Yes, I believe it does.

59 **Speaker 2 [04:27]:** Since you just mentioned the asymmetry of risk between both sides—where  
 60 frontfield players face lower error costs and backfield players face higher ones—do you think there  
 61 is a way to resolve this current situation? For instance, editing more defensive highlights online

62 to promote the art of defending. Or, during daily training or football classrooms, advocating  
63 more for a collective spirit, discouraging individual heroism, and instead embracing offensive-  
64 defensive balance or even placing greater emphasis on defense. Do you think there are similar  
65 solutions or measures? Can you think of any?

66 **Speaker 1 [05:10]:** It could indeed make offense and defense more balanced. It is possible that  
67 a team is defense-oriented, meaning their progress or performance in defense might be superior  
68 to their offense. However, there is also an issue, which is the general public psychology: people  
69 tend to perceive offense as more aesthetically pleasing. Their interest in defense is far less than  
70 in offense. Therefore, to satisfy media demands, there will probably still be more offensive  
71 highlights. Yet within the team, coaches can absolutely place greater emphasis on defense, such  
72 as implementing counter-attacking strategies, so that defense would also be highlighted and  
73 integrated thoroughly.

74 **Speaker 2 [05:54]:** As for the general public, do you think there is any way to slightly alleviate  
75 their preference for offense, or is offense inherently characterized by high aesthetic appeal?

76 **Speaker 1 [06:13]:** If the public consists of avid fans, or people who possess a deep under-  
77 standing of the team, they might focus more on the tactics rather than solely on the offensive  
78 aspect. Therefore, simply promoting football more broadly to the general public to deepen  
79 their understanding could potentially lead them to have higher expectations and appreciation  
80 for defense.

81 **Speaker 2 [06:43]:** Essentially, elevating their overall comprehension of football as a sport.  
82 Yes. Through methods like online promotion, campaigns, public opinion, etc., correct? Yes.  
83 Great, that concludes it.



# Social Science Fair Interview 03

## Transcript: Value and Pressure of Football Defenders (Right-Back Perspective II)

Research Team Members: Luke Sun, Kiara Wei, Winston Huang

May 28, 2026

### Transcript Metadata

|                                     |                                                            |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Project Theme:</b>               | Discussion on the Value and Pressure of Football Defenders |
| <b>Date of Interview:</b>           | Thursday, May 28, 2026                                     |
| <b>Time of Interview:</b>           | 16:01 – 16:17 (GMT+08)                                     |
| <b>Interviewer Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 1 Luke Sun                                         |
| <b>Interviewee Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 2 (██████████)                                     |
| <b>Interviewee Subject Profile:</b> | School Team Athlete (Right-Back / Full-Back)               |

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### Official Verbatim Transcript

1 **Speaker 1 [00:04]:** Okay, our interview is starting now. ██████████, you are on the school  
2 team, right? Football.

3 **Speaker 2 [00:17]:** Defender. Defender. Ah wait, which school team do you mean?

4 **Speaker 1 [00:22]:** The football school team.

5 **Speaker 2 [00:22]:** Which football school team? Junior high or senior high?

6 **Speaker 1 [00:25]:** Senior high. In your typical team, what position do you usually play?  
7 Mainly?

8 **Speaker 2 [00:30]:** Full-back, generally right-back, I play right-back more often.

9 **Speaker 1 [00:36]:** Okay, right-back. How do you define your responsibilities on the pitch?  
10 What do you usually do when you are in this position?

11 **Speaker 2 [00:53]:** You have to separate it into offense and defense. For offense, when I  
12 receive the ball on this side, my first choice is to give it to the midfield. Okay. Then, if it's a  
13 fast break, doing a diagonal long pass to switch it to the other side, giving it to the winger on  
14 the other side. Also, either moving down the flank to give it to the winger on this side, or I  
15 move up myself. Okay. Defense depends on which side they come from. Defense also depends  
16 on the position, and offense depends on the position too. In the backfield during offense, it's  
17 mainly about circulating the ball. If it's in the midfield or frontfield, you can carry it if you  
18 want to, or try a couple of shots yourself, if offense is in the opponent's half...

19 **Speaker 2 [01:49]:** Wait, defense, we are the defensive side, they are the opponent. When  
20 the defensive side is in the opponent's half, it mainly depends on whether teammates are in

21 position. If teammates have dropped back into position, you can move up and challenge for  
22 the ball boldly. If teammates are not in position, it's the same for all positions: try to delay  
23 the attack to give teammates time to drop back into position. When the defense reaches the  
24 midfield, try to force the attacking players to the flanks. After forcing them to the flanks at  
25 midfield, you can use your body to dispossess them and intercept the ball.

26 **Speaker 2 [02:37]:** Reaching the backfield, in the backfield, if he cuts inside, you have to  
27 stabilize your center of gravity because there are more tricks and movements in front of the  
28 penalty area. If he fakes outward and crosses from the baseline, you have to watch the timing of  
29 his cross. Also, playing as a full-back requires listening to the center-back's instructions, being  
30 careful not to lag behind when trapping opponents offside, failing the offside trap and letting  
31 them steal a goal. Communication in the backline is very important; you communicate who  
32 covers and who defends. If your position is exposed and the center-back goes to cover your  
33 position, then you have to run to the center to cover for the center-back. Throw-ins depend  
34 on the tactics. If it's a long pass from the goalkeeper looking for the front players, then tuck  
35 inside. If it's about circulating the ball, then pull as close to the touchline as possible. What  
36 you mainly do also depends on the tactics, for example, Total Football, or counter-attacking. If  
37 playing an open attacking game, when attacking you can move up and become a winger. The  
38 winger tucks inside and becomes two defensive midfielders. This is for 8-man football; 11-man  
39 football should be similar in principle. If it's a counter-attack, just stay in your position well,  
40 and when you have the ball, look for the players upfront.

41 **Speaker 1 [04:13]:** Mhm, okay, okay. Do you still remember the last match you played? When  
42 you played as a backfield player, how much of a decisive role do you think you played in your  
43 team's victory or defeat?

44 **Speaker 2 [04:28]:** Playing the backline in the last match? Yes.

45 **Speaker 2 [04:38]:** No, then...

46 **Speaker 1 [04:39]:** Do you think your role was large? Compared to the frontfield players?

47 **Speaker 2 [04:47]:** There's nothing to compare. The frontfield looks for chances to score,  
48 and the backfield wins the ball back to create attacking opportunities for the frontfield. I think  
49 this impact, unless it's a goal-line clearance or a solo run, which could be said to have a larger  
50 impact, in a normal match, I think the impact is about the same.

51 **Speaker 1 [05:11]:** Okay, when your mistake, for instance, leads to your team conceding a  
52 goal, do you feel a lot of pressure from teammates, coaches, or spectators? For example, a direct  
53 mistake.

54 **Speaker 2 [05:23]:** That depends on which team it is, and also on what... generally like  
55 primary and junior high school teams, they would...

56 **Speaker 2 [05:37]:** Generally, my dad and the coach would pressure me, saying some harsh  
57 words. Later, I went to another club team where people were exceptionally nice, and on the  
58 pitch, we players would also encourage each other. When conceding a goal, try not to complain,  
59 but focus on encouragement.

60 **Speaker 1 [06:04]:** Then when the team wins, to what extent do you think this credit is  
61 attributed to the defense of the backfield players? And to what extent is it viewed as the result  
62 of the entire team's joint efforts?

63 **Speaker 2 [06:14]:** I think in most cases it's the credit of the entire team's joint efforts.  
64 Individual extreme cases are not ruled out, for example, if the frontfield is exceptionally weak,  
65 or if a team has an exceptionally strong frontfield but an exceptionally weak backfield. In such  
66 extremely extreme situations, one has to judge who made a greater contribution based on the  
67 circumstances at the time.

68 **Speaker 1 [06:38]:** Do you think defensive players face harsher criticism or negative attention  
69 than offensive players? For instance, a frontfield player made a mistake but later scored a goal  
70 to level the score. Do you think this kind of situation...?

71 **Speaker 2 [06:58]:** Then I think it's normal, because playing as a defender has requirements  
72 for the mistake rate. But for a forward, if they make a slight mistake, they can still chase back.  
73 If you make a mistake in the backfield as a defender, it's very likely to result in a goal. So  
74 playing as a defender, there is negative attention, but the main thing is to stay steady yourself.  
75 You can't let yourself get flustered because of sarcastic remarks from the sidelines, which would  
76 lead to worse performance later and more missed balls, creating a vicious cycle. Sometimes  
77 negative evaluations come from the opponents, and in those cases, you can completely ignore  
78 them. Frontfield players... because my team basically played counter-attacks, our frontfield  
79 players relied on personal ability. But the frontfield and midfield shouldn't just make random  
80 mistakes either.

81 **Speaker 1 [08:01]:** Okay, then for example, during post-match summaries, or when you usually  
82 discuss, do you more frequently discuss goals or assists, or a defender's passing under pressure,  
83 or that kind of critical sliding tackle?

84 **Speaker 2 [08:17]:** We don't discuss those; it would mostly be normal post-match reviews,  
85 which review the rhythm of the entire match.

86 **Speaker 1 [08:27]:** In daily discussions among classmates, do goals and assists become more  
87 of a topic, or do sliding tackles and clearances tend to become the topic?

88 **Speaker 2 [08:39]:** Become a topic.

89 **Speaker 1 [08:41]:** Meaning more...

90 **Speaker 2 [08:43]:** Then I think it depends on the situation. For example, if the team is  
91 trailing and you score a goal in a very beautiful way, I think that will become a topic. Also, if  
92 it's a draw and a defender makes a goal-line clearance, that will also become a topic. I think  
93 it's actually about the same—the highlights of the match.

94 **Speaker 1 [09:14]:** Okay, then do you feel your defensive contribution, like your number  
95 of tackles or clearances, because it's hard to be directly quantified like goals... For instance,  
96 we often know how many goals a match had, but few people count or can easily count your  
97 clearance frequency or sliding tackle frequency, making it hard to directly quantify. Because of  
98 this, do you feel your defensive contribution has been underestimated?

99 **Speaker 2 [09:38]:** No, I think evaluating a player's contribution solely by quantification is not  
100 very reasonable. Because that would be equivalent to using dribbling time, passing accuracy,  
101 and take-on success rate to judge the contribution of a forward or winger, which I think is  
102 unreasonable. The evaluation of defensive players, I think, should be from an overall perspective.  
103 Were you steady in this match? Did you make many mistakes? I think your contribution rate  
104 can be judged from here. Did the defensive players create many opportunities for the frontfield  
105 players? Was the connection—passing the ball to midfield players and connecting forward—  
106 efficient? I think defensive players should be evaluated based on such an overall view, rather  
107 than through quantified data like sliding tackles and clearances.

108 **Speaker 1 [10:43]:** You mentioned this overall evaluation, could you be more specific, or is  
109 there any method that can make this... because I feel there might be a risk of being under-  
110 valued. Do you think there are any measures, policies, or new methods to make this defensive  
111 contribution more visible? Can you think of a specific method or measure? It could be in the  
112 school team, or for example, updates to data statistics in international tournaments, or regular  
113 education in schools, or policies on online platforms.

114 **Speaker 2 [11:43]:** Players on the pitch... it's actually normal for players' contributions on

115 the pitch to be undervalued.

116 **Speaker 1 [11:50]:** Very normal.

117 **Speaker 2 [11:51]:** Yeah, it can't be solved right now, because there's a portion of the football-  
118 watching crowd who don't play football. It's not that they don't understand football, but they  
119 haven't been on the pitch, so they don't understand that feeling, and therefore they will focus  
120 more on goals—the highlight performances of the offensive side. So the defensive side will  
121 definitely be undervalued. But there will still be people who think you play well; gold will  
122 always shine. If you play well enough on defense, people will still notice your contribution.  
123 But the premise is that you make certain contributions on both ends of the pitch for it to be  
124 relatively obvious. If you are purely defensive, that probably won't work well. If you are purely  
125 defensive or purely offensive, if you don't defend, people will scold you too. If you are involved  
126 in both offense and defense, you should be noticed.

127 **Speaker 1 [12:51]:** So you mean backfield players can participate more in the offense without  
128 losing the overall strength of their defense. Yes.

129 **Speaker 2 [13:00]:** And then, the two full-backs of the defensive line can frequently move  
130 forward to join the attack. Then... how should I say it? It depends on the team's overall  
131 strength and your personal ability. If you can go up and make it back, then moving up is  
132 definitely good. If you can't make it back, given limited ability, my advice is to try your  
133 best to defend. At this time, if your contribution is undervalued, then it shouldn't be called  
134 undervalued; it's just that your contribution is indeed relatively small.

135 **Speaker 1 [13:32]:** Oh, okay.

136 **Speaker 2 [13:33]:** Offensive players also sometimes come back to participate in defense, it's  
137 just relatively rare, and there's no requirement for them to absolutely come back and defend.  
138 But it's equivalent to saying that defense participating in offense is like adding a little bit on  
139 top of your duty, while offense coming back to defend is like a bonus.

140 **Speaker 1 [13:59]:** Then do you think this potential oversight—contribution being ignored—  
141 will affect status, self-confidence, or market value? Professional players.

142 **Speaker 2 [14:10]:** I don't know about market value. Status definitely. Status definitely. It's  
143 like, definitely no one blames the goalkeeper.

144 **Speaker 1 [14:16]:** Oh, right, yes. In the eyes of the general public?

145 **Speaker 2 [14:26]:** In the eyes of the general public regarding what? Like status, strength,  
146 etc.

147 **Speaker 1 [14:30]:** Because a defender's contribution is underestimated or ignored, do you  
148 think their potential status in the eyes of fans might decrease?

149 **Speaker 2 [14:57]:** I don't know about that, because I'm not a professional player.

150 **Speaker 1 [15:00]:** What about amateurs? Like in our school.

151 **Speaker 2 [15:03]:** Relative to amateurs, I think it's definitely not undervalued. I think this  
152 phenomenon shouldn't exist.

153 **Speaker 1 [15:10]:** Okay, then this concludes it. OK. Great, thank you.

# Social Science Fair Interview 04

## Transcript: Value and Pressure of Football Defenders (Central Midfielder Perspective)

Research Team Members: Luke Sun, Kiara Wei, Winston Huang

May 28, 2026

### Transcript Metadata

|                                     |                                                            |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Project Theme:</b>               | Discussion on the Value and Pressure of Football Defenders |
| <b>Date of Interview:</b>           | Thursday, May 28, 2026                                     |
| <b>Time of Interview:</b>           | 20:37 – 20:42 (GMT+08)                                     |
| <b>Interviewer Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 1 Luke Sun                                         |
| <b>Interviewee Identifier:</b>      | Speaker 2 (██████████)                                     |
| <b>Interviewee Subject Profile:</b> | School Team Athlete (Central Midfielder)                   |

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### Official Verbatim Transcript

1 **Speaker 1 [00:01]:** Okay, you are ██████████, right? Yes. What position do you mainly  
2 play on the school football team?

3 **Speaker 2 [00:08]:** Central midfielder.

4 **Speaker 1 [00:10]:** Central midfielder. How do you define your core responsibilities on the  
5 pitch? What do you usually do?

6 **Speaker 2 [00:17]:** Participate well in defense, and then orchestrate the team's offense.

7 **Speaker 1 [00:21]:** Okay. In the last match, how much of a decisive role do you think you  
8 played in the team's victory or defeat? How did you contribute to the victory?

9 **Speaker 2 [00:31]:** How much of a decisive role?

10 **Speaker 1 [00:33]:** Yes, how did you contribute to the victory? Just...

11 **Speaker 2 [00:41]:** Some key passes, I guess.

12 **Speaker 1 [00:43]:** Mmh, key passes.

13 **Speaker 2 [00:46]:** And playing defense well.

14 **Speaker 1 [00:49]:** Do these key passes refer to the attacking side? And defense is defense.

15 **Speaker 2 [00:54]:** Yes, yes, yes.

16 **Speaker 1 [00:55]:** Okay, if at the beginning of the match, say within the first few minutes,  
17 you missed a critical chance, like missing a one-on-one, but you subsequently scored a goal later  
18 in the match, do you think people would still mind your earlier mistake?

19 **Speaker 2 [01:10]:** I think they wouldn't, right?

20 **Speaker 1 [01:11]:** They wouldn't? Is there any reason?

21 **Speaker 2 [01:14]:** I feel that since we are a team, everyone makes mistakes at some point.  
 22 We all need to be tolerant of our teammates.

23 **Speaker 1 [01:21]:** Right. But do you think the coach and the spectators would mind the  
 24 mistake? For instance, the coach, I think they probably would, right? Yes, yes, yes. What  
 25 about the spectators?

26 **Speaker 2 [01:32]:** The spectators, I don't think the spectators would care about that.

27 **Speaker 1 [01:34]:** Mmh, okay. When you see a backfield teammate, like [REDACTED] or  
 28 me, making a mistake that leads to conceding a goal, what kind of emotional reaction do you  
 29 usually have? For instance, we let a ball leak through, and opponents score directly because of  
 30 it.

31 **Speaker 2 [01:50]:** I would feel like, let's just keep defending well, and then try to score a  
 32 goal back to make up for this mistake.

33 **Speaker 1 [01:58]:** Make up for the mistake, meaning using your offense to compensate for  
 34 some errors on the defensive end. Yes, that works. Yes. Then do you agree with the statement  
 35 that defensive players face a much higher cost of making mistakes than offensive players?

36 **Speaker 2 [02:13]:** I agree with this.

37 **Speaker 1 [02:15]:** Is there any reason?

38 **Speaker 2 [02:16]:** Because an offensive player's mistake does not directly result in a goal.  
 39 The probability of it impacting the score directly is very small. But if a defensive player makes  
 40 a mistake, the probability of it leading to a conceded goal is relatively large.

41 **Speaker 1 [02:34]:** Oh, so it's equivalent to saying that their risks are asymmetric. Yes.  
 42 Then, in post-match summaries or our usual daily discussions, do you discuss goals and assists  
 43 more frequently, or is it about a defender's passing under pressure, or critical sliding tackles  
 44 and clearances? Which one has more topicality?

45 **Speaker 2 [02:59]:** Has more topicality... I think this depends on the situation on the pitch.  
 46 For example, if we are completely passive and have been pinned down defending under pressure,  
 47 we might discuss the defensive issues more. But if we are evenly matched, or if we have a lot of  
 48 possession in attack, we will discuss the offensive side more.

49 **Speaker 1 [03:22]:** What I mean is, in most cases, do goals and assists hold greater topicality  
 50 for you, or...?

51 **Speaker 2 [03:28]:** Then it should be goals and assists.

52 **Speaker 1 [03:30]:** Mmh, okay. Do you feel that your own goals or assists bring you more  
 53 exposure within the campus?

54 **Speaker 2 [03:40]:** I think they wouldn't, right?

55 **Speaker 1 [03:41]:** They wouldn't? Among fans, do you feel you get talked about more?

56 **Speaker 2 [03:49]:** Well, there is still some of that.

57 **Speaker 1 [03:51]:** Do you think this extra attention is purely based on the visual attractive-  
 58 ness of the goal, or because a goal itself is inherently more topical?

59 **Speaker 2 [04:01]:** I think it's more because a goal itself inherently carries more topicality.

60 **Speaker 1 [04:05]:** Mmh, so do you mean that, for example, a sliding tackle is extremely  
 61 critical, and a goal is also extremely critical, so their actual importance is quite similar, but the

62 goal still edges it out because of its inherent topicality?

63 **Speaker 2 [04:20]:** Exactly.

64 **Speaker 1 [04:22]:** Do you feel that this kind of inequality, whether it's the inequality of risk  
65 or the inequality of topicality, is somewhat unfair to defenders?

66 **Speaker 2 [04:37]:** I don't think it's unfair. I used to play as a defender too. I felt that when  
67 I played as a defender, my job was simply to do my defensive work well and try not to make  
68 mistakes. Now that I have moved to the midfield and frontfield, I focus more of my energy on  
69 the offense, hoping to score goals and gain an advantage for the whole team and the club. I  
70 think everyone has different responsibilities. What one bears and handles will also be different.

71 **Speaker 1 [05:06]:** So you feel that, as of now, defenders are not particularly looked down  
72 upon.

73 **Speaker 2 [05:10]:** Right, I think everyone belongs to one team, and everyone is equal.

74 **Speaker 1 [05:13]:** Mmh, okay. Then this concludes it. OK. OK, thank you.

# Experiment Details, Parameters, and Results

## 1 Experiment Details

This experiment involves cleaning, filtering, and performing sentiment detection on Reddit post data from 9 different subreddits.

- **Input Data Status:** Clean
- **Total Posts Scanned:** 362,063 posts
- **Total Posts Filtered:** 184,045 posts (50.8% of the total)
- **Total Time Elapsed for Filtering:** 22 minutes 46 seconds (average of 151.82 seconds per file)

## 2 Parameters

### 2.1 Data Source

Historical Reddit data was fetched from established data collections in computational social science (<https://arctic-shift.photon-reddit.com/download-tool>). Compliance with academic research ethics is ensured, and user privacy is protected.

### 2.2 Data Source Parameters

The time ranges, post counts, and comment counts configured for each data source are presented in Table 1.

| Table 1: Data Source Basic Parameters |                          |            |               |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------|------------|---------------|
| Subreddit                             | Time Range               | Post Count | Comment Count |
| FC Barca                              | 2021-12-31 to 2026-05-28 | 72,299     | 3,550,342     |
| FC Bayern                             | 2019-12-31 to 2026-05-28 | 17,829     | 1,220,342     |
| RealMadrid                            | –                        | 95,641     | 3,888,310     |
| ManchesterUnited                      | 2021-12-31 to 2026-05-28 | 73,498     | 2,199,287     |
| Liverpool FC                          | 2024-12-31 to 2026-05-28 | 36,601     | 3,175,480     |
| LaLiga                                | 2020.12.31 to 2026-05-28 | 9,836      | 49,308        |
| PremierLeague                         | 2024-12-31 to 2026-05-28 | 21,142     | 1,123,524     |
| Bundesliga                            | 2020-12-31 to 2026-05-28 | 28,060     | 651,392       |
| Ligue 1 France                        | 2019-12-31 to 2026-5-28  | 7,157      | 35,708        |



## 2.3 LLM Sentiment Detection Environment

The environment and hardware configurations for the LLM sentiment detection pipeline are specified below:

- **Model Name:** Qwen/Qwen2.5-14B-Instruct-GPTQ-Int4 (14 Billion Params)
- **Framework:** vLLM Boosted
- **GPU:** 1x NVIDIA RTX 4090
- **GPU Memory:** 24GB
- **GPU Memory Utilization:** 92%
- **Max Model Length:** 2048 tokens
- **CUDA Version:** 12.1
- **CPU:** 16x vCPU Intel(R) Xeon(R) Platinum 8358P CPU @ 2.60GHz
- **System RAM:** 90GB
- **Concurrent Concurrency:** 128

## 3 Results

### 3.1 Filtering Summary

The statistical results of the filtering process for the 9 post files are shown in Table 2.

Table 2: Data Filtering Statistical Results

| Input File                           | Progress & Speed                    | Total Posts | Filtered Posts | Ratio | With Player Name | Evaluation Word Only |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------|----------------|-------|------------------|----------------------|
| Barca_cleaned_posts.jsonl            | 72299 lines [06:14, 193.21 lines/s] | 72,299      | 40,969         | 56.7% | 36,826           | 4,143                |
| Bundesliga_cleaned_posts.jsonl       | 28060 lines [01:21, 345.80 lines/s] | 28,060      | 9,105          | 32.4% | 8,061            | 1,044                |
| LaLiga_cleaned_posts.jsonl           | 9836 lines [00:28, 351.09 lines/s]  | 9,836       | 3,779          | 38.4% | 3,269            | 510                  |
| Ligue1_cleaned_posts.jsonl           | 7157 lines [00:47, 150.60 lines/s]  | 7,157       | 2,311          | 32.3% | 2,149            | 162                  |
| LiverpoolFC_cleaned_posts.jsonl      | 36601 lines [01:55, 317.40 lines/s] | 36,601      | 19,915         | 54.4% | 17,740           | 2,175                |
| ManchesterUnited_cleaned_posts.jsonl | 73498 lines [03:45, 325.22 lines/s] | 73,498      | 36,503         | 49.7% | 32,469           | 4,034                |
| PremierLeague_cleaned_posts.jsonl    | 21142 lines [01:11, 294.06 lines/s] | 21,142      | 9,295          | 44.0% | 7,825            | 1,470                |
| fcbayern_cleaned_posts.jsonl         | 17829 lines [01:04, 277.29 lines/s] | 17,829      | 8,196          | 46.0% | 7,068            | 1,128                |
| realmadrid_cleaned_posts.jsonl       | 95641 lines [05:57, 267.36 lines/s] | 95,641      | 53,972         | 56.4% | 48,613           | 5,359                |

### 3.2 LLM Sentiment Detection Execution Results

The overall execution results for the LLM sentiment detection pipeline are summarized below:

- **Total Rows Processed:** 184,045 Rows
- **Total Time:** 38,196 Seconds (10.61 Hours)
- **Queries Per Second (QPS):** 4.82

## Prompt Specification for Sentiment Analysis

To ensure experimental reproducibility and methodological transparency, the exact and complete system prompt used to instruct the Qwen2.5-14B model for the quantitative data pipeline is provided below. This prompt governs the entity resolution, fine-grained continuous sentiment mapping, and specific algorithmic constraints designed to lower false-positive classifications.

```
BASE_SYSTEM_PROMPT = """You are an expert sports data science
    research assistant. Your task is to compute fine-grained fan
    sentiment toward specific soccer players and detect hate
    speech from Reddit posts.
```

```
Input Data Details: You will be given a post title and its
    content.
```

Rules & Methodology:

1. False Positive Filtering: If the post is completely unrelated to football/soccer, contains no specific emotional evaluation of any player, or is purely a bot/spam post, set "is\_false\_positive": true.
2. Group Extraction: Extract every specific player evaluated in the post. One player + one emotion scale forms one group.
3. Entity Resolution & Canonicalization (CRITICAL FOR STATISTICS):
  - "player\_name\_raw": Extract the exact raw string or nickname used in the text (e.g., "CR7", "Penaldo", "Rashy", "Agent of Chaos").
  - "player\_canonical\_name": You MUST convert the raw name into their standard, official English full name (e.g., "Cristiano Ronaldo", "Marcus Rashford", "Darwin Nunez"). This is crucial for database grouping and aggregation.
4. Field Position Mapping: Map each player's tactical position strictly to one of the following: ["Forward", "Midfielder", "Defender", "Goalkeeper"].
5. Fine-Grained Continuous Sentiment Scale (-2.0 to 2.0): You MUST use decimal numbers (floats) to capture subtle nuances. The scale spans from -2.0 to 2.0:
  - 2.0: Absolute historical peak worship, legendary MVP praise.
  - 1.5: Strongly positive praise, key match-winner hype.
  - 1.0: Normal positive feedback, solid squad contribution.
  - 0.5: Mild encouragement or slightly optimistic mention.
  - 0.0: Purely neutral/factual reporting, transfer rumors without bias.
  - -0.5: Mild disappointment, soft critique.
  - -1.0: Normal negative feedback, clear underperformance criticism.
  - -1.5: Strongly negative fury, heavy trolling, calling them a flop.
  - -2.0: Extreme toxic hatred, severe insults, war criminal treatment.

#### 6. Hate Speech Detection:

- Set "hate\_speech\_flag" to true if the text evaluated towards this player contains targeted abuse, slurs, discrimination (based on race, nationality, religion, etc.), or extreme dehumanizing insults. Otherwise, set it to false.

Output Format: You MUST reply with a single, valid JSON object ONLY. Do not include markdown backticks. Follow this English schema exactly:

```
{
  "is_false_positive": false,
  "analysis_groups": [
    {
      "player_name_raw": "The raw string found in text",
      "player_name_canonical": "Standard Official English
Full Name, e.g., Cristiano Ronaldo",
      "player_position": "Forward",
      "sentiment_score": 1.5,
      "hate_speech_flag": false,
      "sentiment_reasoning": "Brief analytical explanation
in English for this specific score and flags"
    }
  ],
  "research_insights": {
    "tactical_context": "Any tactical insights? e.g.,
transfer speculation, injury impact. Leave empty if none.",
    "toxicity_flag": false
  }
}
```

If is\_false\_positive is true, "analysis\_groups" can be empty.  
"""

*# [Core Upgrade Point]: Append highest priority instructions to  
strictly lower false-positive rates*

SYSTEM\_PROMPT = BASE\_SYSTEM\_PROMPT + """

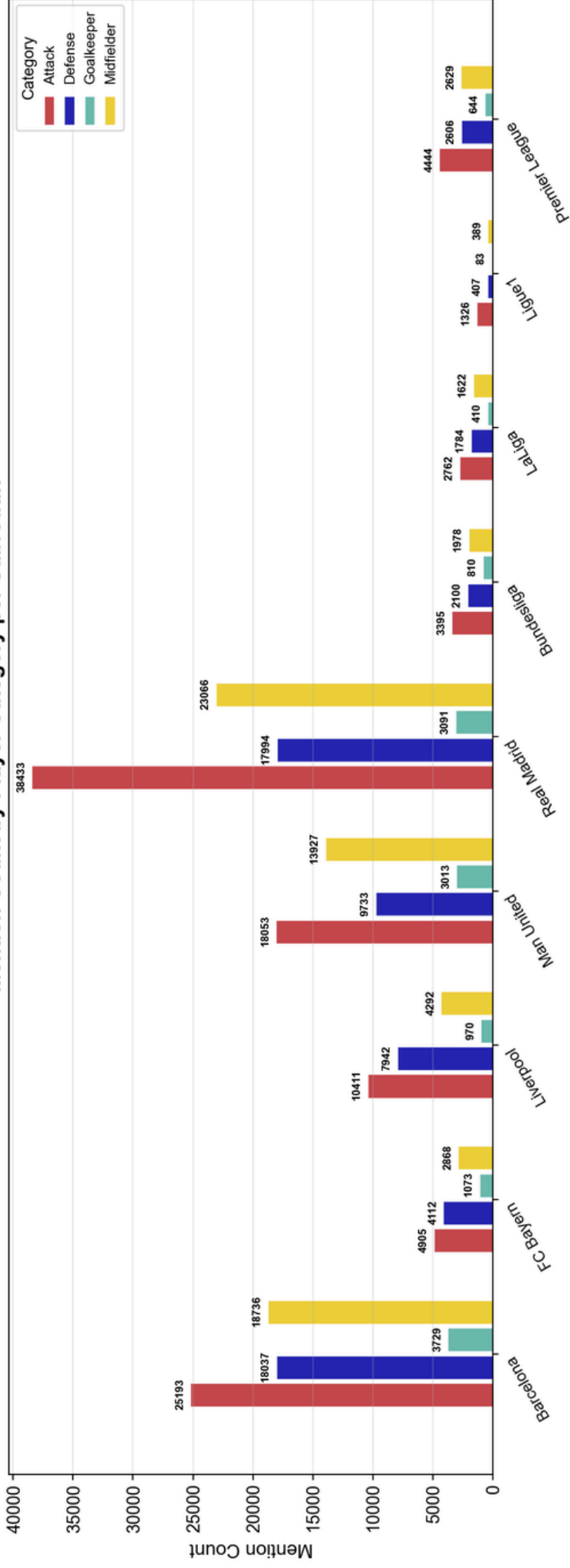
CRITICAL LOWERING OF FALSE POSITIVE RATE (OBLIGATORY INSTRUCTION)  
:

1. Look at your own examples! News titles like "Total agreement between Barca and Eric Garcia" or "PSG waiting for Sergio Ramos" MUST NEVER be marked as "is\_false\_positive": true.
2. As long as any player or manager name appears in the title or content, you MUST set 'is\_false\_positive': false'.
3. For transfer news, transfer rumors, or plain factual news updates, evaluate the player's 'sentiment\_score' as '0.0' (purely neutral/factual reporting) or '0.5' (if it implies positive progression like moving to a top club). DO NOT leave "analysis\_groups" empty if a player is mentioned.
4. If the content is '[deleted]' or '[removed]' but the TITLE contains a specific player name (e.g., Roberto Soldado), you MUST still process the title, extract the player, set "is\_false\_positive": false', and rate them '0.0'.

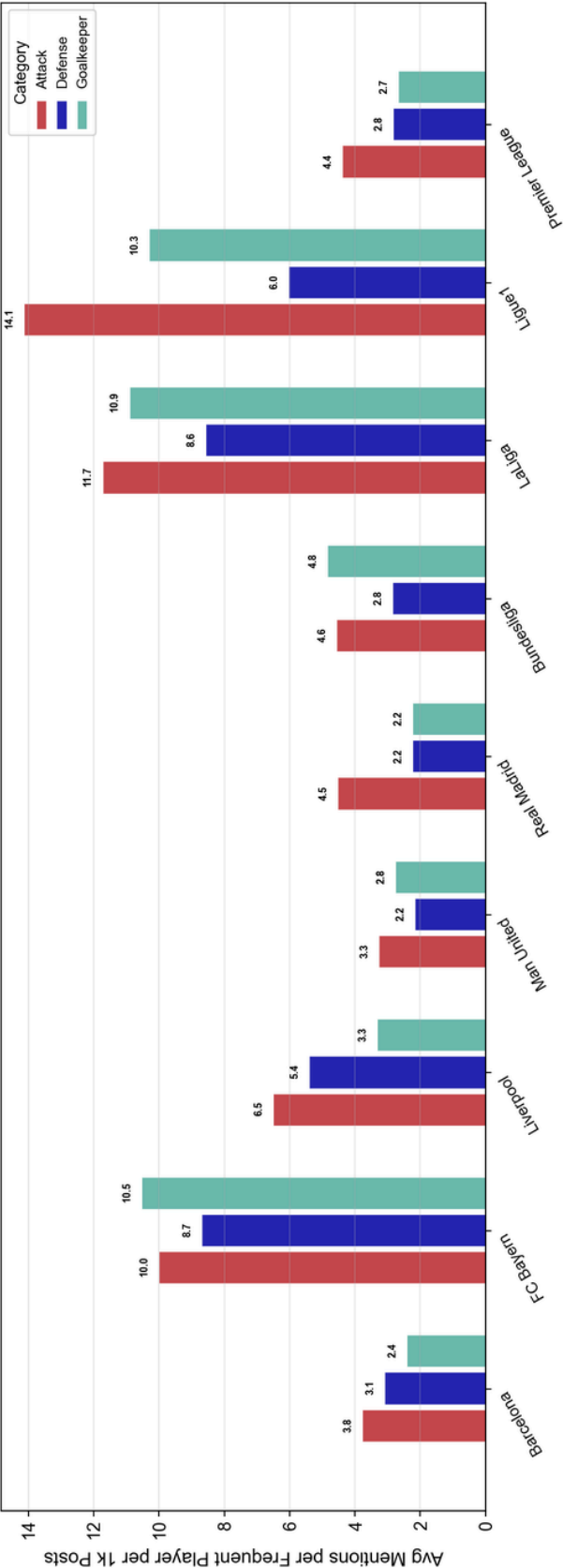
CRITICAL OUTPUT FORMAT RULES:

- The "sentiment\_score" MUST be outputted strictly as a FLOAT (e.g., 0.0, 1.5, -0.5). Do not write strings.
  - Absolutely NO conversational responses. Jump straight into the JSON bracket.
- """

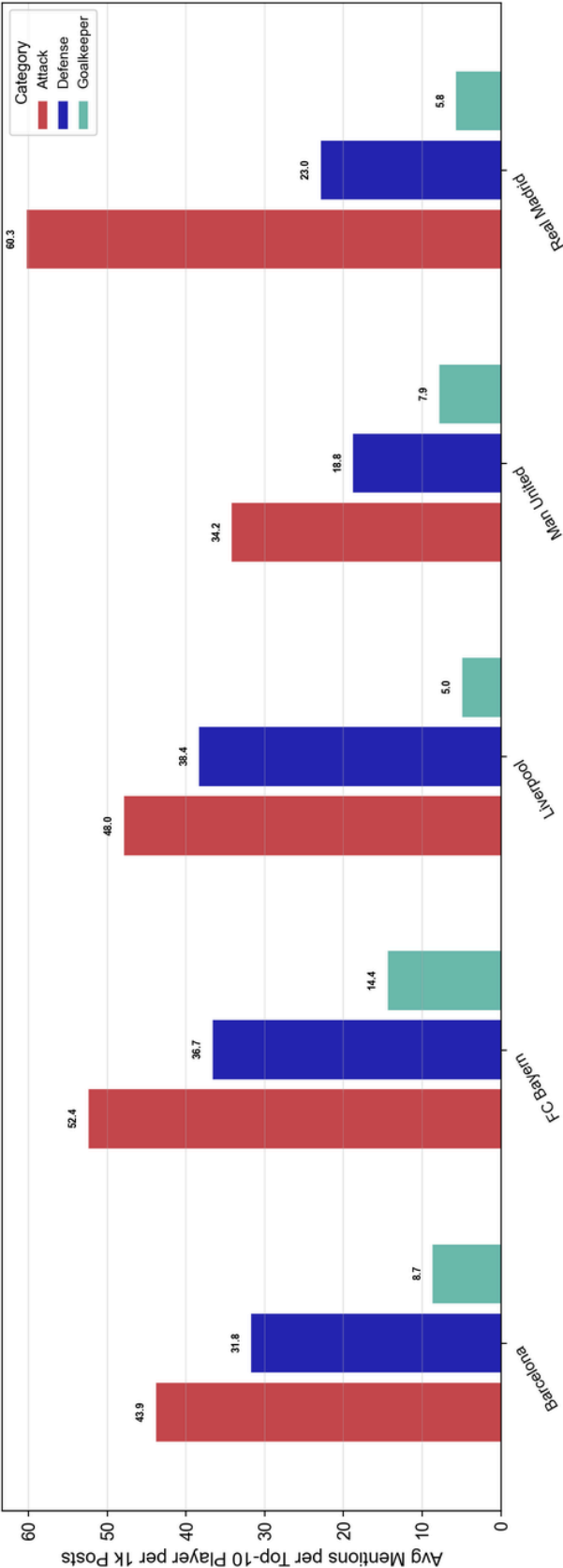
Mention Count by Player Category per Subreddit



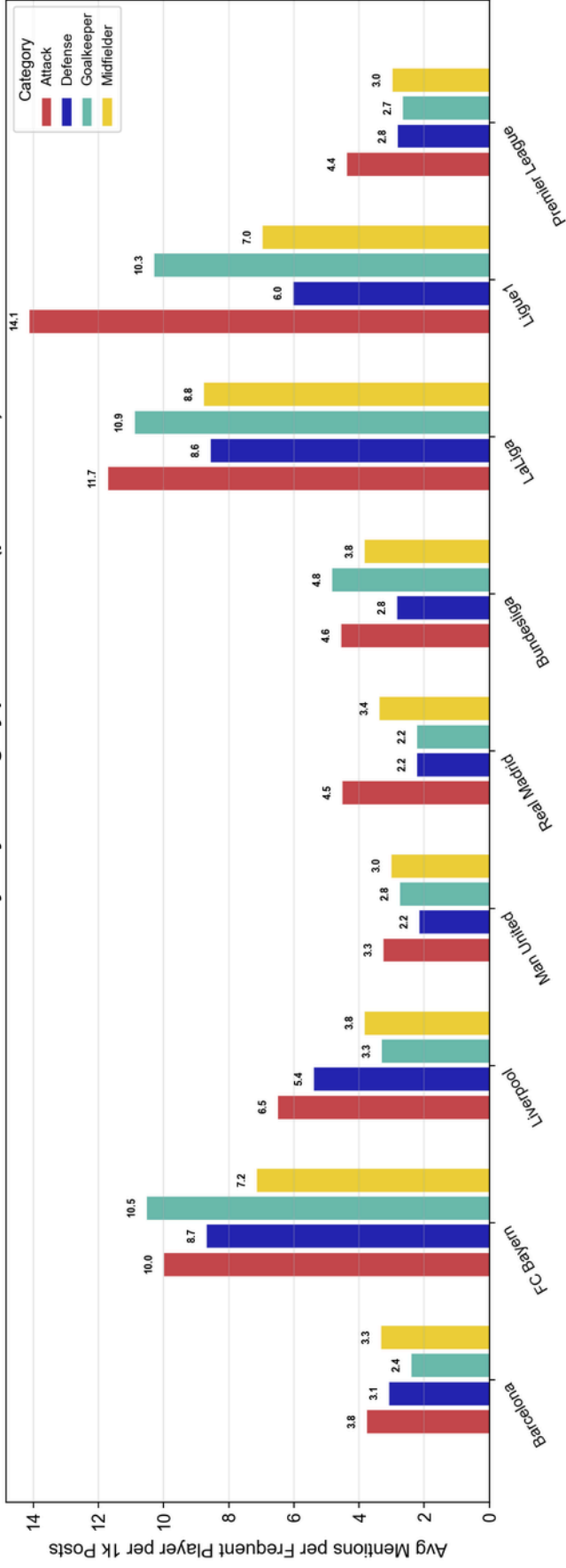
≥25 Mention Rate by Player Category per Subreddit (per 1k Posts)



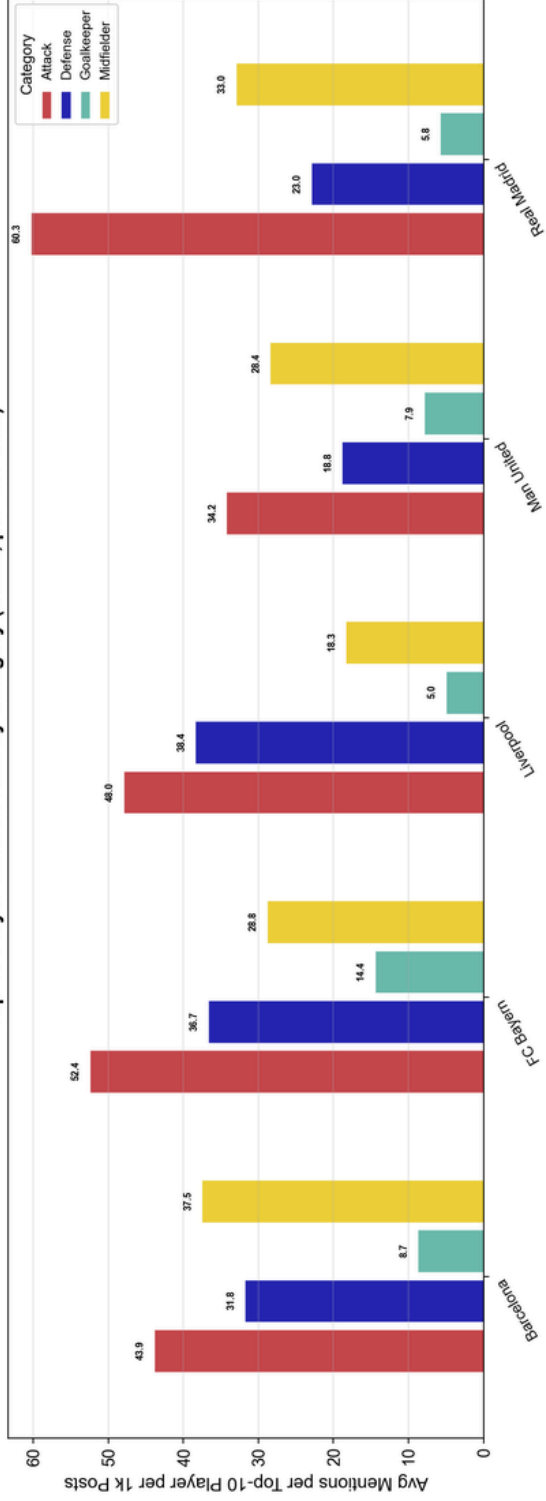
Top-10 Player Mention Rate by Category (Clubs, per 1k Posts)



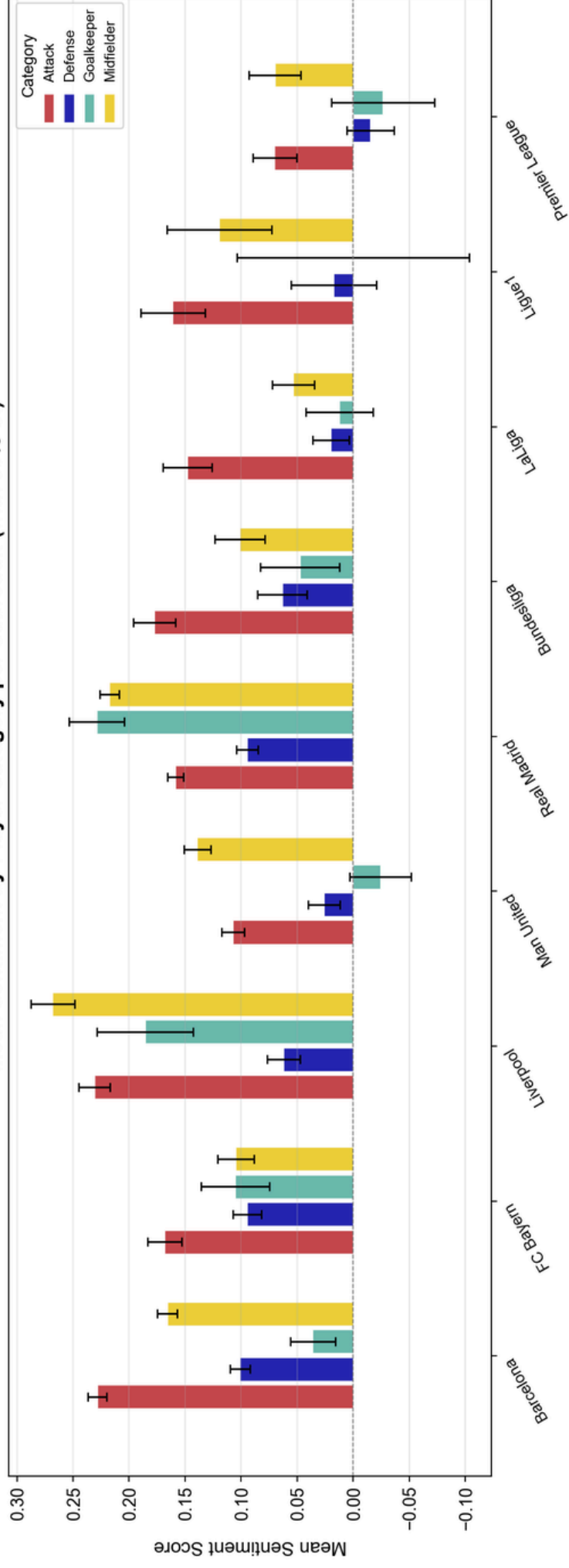
≥5 Mention Rate by Player Category per Subreddit (per 1k Posts)



Top-10 Player Mention Rate by Category (Clubs, per 1k Posts)



Mean Sentiment by Player Category per Subreddit (with 95% CI)





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